

Chapter 1—Courtesy Reminder

Under the Viaduct, rain lacquered the Lakeside Sprawl and then shattered it into light.

**TONE. AMBER. MANUAL REVIEW PENDING. DELAY
SURCHARGE: POSTED.**

The plate didn't tone at the man ahead of her this time. It clicked at Izzy:

**STEP ASIDE FOR SAFETY. TIME TO RESOLUTION:
00:01:58.**

Izzy obeyed because arguing was a handshake, and handshakes were how the city learned you existed. She counted primes under her breath—two, three, five—anything but the prompt.

A woman was already standing in the wedge—hood down, hands lifted the way cameras liked. A clinic escort kept one palm lightly on her shoulder, not quite a hold, not quite a comfort.

The woman's throat patch was the cheap kind: a translucent square with a faint blue pulse under the skin. A status ribbon scrolled across it in tiny, polite text:

**RECOVERY SILENCE: ACTIVE (LEVEL 3).
STABILITY WINDOW: 00:04:12.
COOPERATION REDUCES SUFFERING.**

Her lips moved anyway. No sound came. Just breath and the smallest tremor in her jaw, like her body was trying to remember how to be a person out loud.

The escort leaned close and spoke the phrase for her—soft, practiced, almost tender. The patch brightened as if it had been fed.

The plate at the door chimed once and displayed a name Izzy hadn't asked to know:

**ANIKA ROSS. OPTIMIZATION COMPLETE.
THANK YOU FOR CHOOSING CARE.**

Izzy looked away too fast. The reflex was old and ugly: don't witness what you can't afford to pay for.

She stepped into the painted wedge beside the door and felt the crowd slide around her—boots splashing, shoulders brushing, a courier's spine rig hissing past like she'd become furniture.

Her glasses posted the surcharge to her balance with the same warmth it used for weather updates. Pocket change. Permanent record.

By the time the door finally relented, the rhythm of the flow had shifted. The small window she'd been threading herself through—two cameras out of sync, one dome on a lazy sweep—was gone.

Izzy kept her hood low and her hands where cameras liked them—visible, calm, compliant. She walked like someone who'd memorized every blind spot the city still allowed, the way you memorize exits in a burning building.

Her glasses skipped frames in the left eye every few steps. A stutter of white where the world should've been. Balance lagged a heartbeat behind her intent, like her body was waiting for a permission signal that never arrived.

The seam ran from the corner of her jaw to the hinge, the port beneath it sitting heavy against bone, a rented part that could decide—any day—it didn't like her terms.

A thin red stripe slid across her glasses banner:

**COURTESY REMINDER.
JAW PORT MAINTENANCE DUE: 4 DAYS.
AUTO-LOCK ELIGIBILITY: ACTIVE.
THANK YOU FOR YOUR COOPERATION.**

She blinked to dismiss it.

Izzy swallowed spit that tasted like metal and kept moving. Around her: after-shift surge spilling out of Union Node into the underways—couriers with spine rigs, clinic techs in clear ponchos, contract workers with fresh bandage collars over fresh ports. People with the Baylight sheen: a slightly too-smooth gait, a slightly too-soft face from algorithmic lighting correction, a slightly too-fast “Good evening\!” because their social layer got a subsidy.

Everyone wore something Baylight could read.

On the platform above, a flood-shift roster rebalanced sanitation crews in real time. A man in city orange stared at the new route, the attendance penalty blinking under it, then lifted his wrist to accept like rent depended on it because it probably did.

And if you were out-of-spec, the city didn’t kick you out.

It invited you in.

Izzy cut past a clinic entrance. The door chimed bright and friendly as she passed. A wall display shifted from an ad to a welcome screen, as if something older than the clinic had noticed her:

HELLO, ISOLDE MERCER. WE’VE MISSED YOU.

Izzy didn’t look back. Transit still saw Saskia Klein; only the deep civic legacy layers remembered Isolde Mercer, and those layers could name her without yet being able to route her.

Looking was how systems decided you’d consented.

Clean.

Like a signature.

HOT / CHEAP / VERIFIED.

Verified was smaller, tucked under the price like a footnote. Like an apology.

Nataliya Woo stood behind the cart with her shoulders hunched under a plastic hood. Dark hair pinned back. Rain made her face look carved—wind-polished, stubborn. A faint clinic patch behind her ear pulsed once when she turned her head, the little light of someone who'd tried to go legit and discovered “legit” was just a different leash.

“Hot pockets,” Nataliya called. “Two for one if you don’t ask what’s in it.”

A kid in a soaked school jacket stepped up, tapped two fingers to their throat, then hovered those fingers over the reader plate. A blue pulse crossed the air—skin to sensor. The plate trilled. Micro-credits flowed out of a body-linked account like blood through a capillary.

Nataliya slid a sleeve over without looking up. “Eat fast,” she said. “Cold hits like debt.”

The kid vanished into the crowd, chewing like warmth was contraband.

Izzy stepped up before she could talk herself out of it.

Nataliya’s gaze didn’t land on Izzy’s face. It dropped to her jawline, where skin met something that wasn’t skin.

“Tap,” Nataliya said. Not unkind. Just tired.

Izzy hesitated. “You don’t have to?”

Nataliya’s eyes flicked past Izzy’s shoulder to a camera dome pretending it wasn’t watching. Her shrug was tiny and sharp: “I do.”

“Thank you for choosing a Verified Vendor,” it said pleasantly. “For your safety, identity assurance is in progress. Please hold.”

Izzy's jaw seam prickled and lit faint amber, static under enamel.

Verify. Hold. Route. Bill. Forget.

Izzy tapped.

A vibration ran up her bones. Her glasses banner flashed a handshake window she hadn't authorized—the system's version of a friendly hello with teeth behind it.

SIGNATURE VERIFYING.

Nataliya didn't look up. Her mouth barely moved. "Hold."

Izzy tried to pull her hand back.

The cart pinged—higher. The panel stuttered once, then snapped into hard text:

SIGNATURE MISMATCH.

ASSISTANCE IS AVAILABLE. MANDATORY ID CHECK.

Izzy's breath caught. "No."

"Please do not remove your hand," the cart said gently. "This will only take a moment."

Izzy yanked her hand away and slammed her palm into the cart's side panel. Metal rang. Nataliya flinched. The reader screen glitched and went black.

For half a second, the world felt quiet.

Then Izzy's glasses banner filled with the real consequence:

COMPLIANCE PING SENT. VENDOR LIABILITY: ACTIVE.

Her thumb hovered. Then she pressed **FAULT**.

The puck toned approval anyway. Above it, her own ledger flashed:

VERIFIED SCORE: DOWNGRADED. PENALTY: PENDING

The VERIFIED tag on the cart's sign blinked once and dimmed.

Nataliya met Izzy's eyes for the first time. "North stairs," she said, barely moving her lips. "Stay under concrete. Then run."

Izzy didn't wait to see if the lie would hold:

**BAYLIGHT SECURITY: SIGNAL ACQUIRED.
WE'RE ON OUR WAY TO ASSIST YOU.**

Izzy tasted cold in her throat. Izzy ran.